far to go. Some argued that China was expansionist, that India should not harm its relations with the Soviet Union by reaching out to China, that India could live with the border dispute, and that any rapprochement would require concessions to India on the border and recognition of Indian positions on Sikkim and Kashmir. Others argued that a rapprochement with China would allow India to reduce dependence on the Soviet Union; eventually to settle the border problem, which was an obstacle to growth and international flexibility and not something India had the capacity to settle by force; to help create a wedge between China and Pakistan; and to exploit the potential for economic interaction. Eventually, as Surjit Mansingh notes, the position that the Indian government took was "more or less a median one: cordiality without excess, talks without negotiation, normalisation without dramatics."[63]

Dual Détentes (1974–1975)

Sino-Indian rapprochement had not been an easy sell domestically in India, but the 1971 war victory and the 1974 nuclear test made the country more confident. Among the public, there was a desire to normalize relations with China even though people continued to have negative opinions of that country. In a poll taken in 1973, 84 percent of respondents had said India's relations with China were not satisfactory, and 42 percent thought that India should continue to try to normalize relations despite China's "unhelpful attitude." Another 27 percent thought India should do so if China reciprocated. Only 20 percent said India should not pursue normalization.[64] Gandhi's political dominance allowed her some flexibility as well, which only increased during the emergency. This allowed her to blunt opposition attacks that her government was weakening India by reaching out to China and Pakistan. It also allowed her to counter criticism from the left that she was hurting India-Soviet relations.[65] The American embassy in Delhi and others detected a rightward shift in 1974–1975 because of economic necessity, the need to correct the imbalance in India's partnerships, and the proclivities of Gandhi's inner circle.[66]

By late 1975–early 1976, there were more positive signals from China, which also seemed apparent to American policymakers. Chinese vice premier Deng Xiaoping had earlier stated to Kissinger in November 1974